

HIGH STAKES US President George W. Bush with Manmohan Singh in New Delhi, Mar. 2006

KALYAN CHAKARAVORTY



▲ Aug. 1, 2005

THE BIG NUKE DEAL

Bush and Manmohan transformed India-US ties through the nuclear deal, ending isolation, forging strategic partnership and securely repositioning India globally



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licence-permit raj baggage, the civil nuclear deal gave him an uncharacteristic muscular image. The Left broke away, but new allies were discovered in a contentious no-confidence vote in parliament in 2008. 'Singh is King' was the Bollywood-style slogan coined for a shy prime minister by cheerleading urban middle classes.

Many saw this deal as the crowning glory of Manmohan Singh's prime ministership. When the Congress triumphed in the 2009 election by crossing the 200-seat mark for the first time since 1984, the Grand Old Party was even more convinced that it was well and truly back in command. The hubris of victory was to prove fatal, setting in chain a series of unanticipated events that would eventually bring on the clouds of doom for the UPA 2. Truthfully, the Congress party under Sonia Gandhi had never quite rediscovered its mojo, the umbilical cord of a family-centric leadership barely holding together a moth-eaten organisational set-up.

Dr Singh, too, was never really a vote-catching 'king' but principally an efficient civil servant who symbolised honesty and decency in public life. Even that halo slowly began to slip away as his government stumbled from one calamity to another. In 2008, the global financial crisis—the subprime crisis, stock market crash and bankruptcy of global financial services firm Lehman Brothers—meant that the benign economic climate was rapidly transformed into a hostile one. The 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks defined a catastrophic period where national security crumbled in the face of deadly Pakistan-sponsored Islamic terror. A series of big-ticket corruption scandals exposed a 'cash and carry' rent-seeking ministerial mindset afflicting the corridors of power. Where a government's survival instincts were applauded in its first term, now they became a grim reminder of the limitations of coalition politics, where no one was quite in charge any longer.

IF ECONOMIC LIBERALISATION HAD PITCHED DR SINGH AS THE PATH-BREAKING FINANCE MINISTER, THE N-DEAL GAVE HIM AN UNCHARACTERISTIC MUSCULAR IMAGE

The final act was when a seemingly innocuous 'India Against Corruption' movement in 2011 triggered a wider anti-